

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

TUESDAY, DECEMBER 17, 2024

Arriving for T riders: ‘Train Daddy Eng’

Sure, lots of work awaits and debt soars, but leader punches a rare ticket: hope

By Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

It was once inconceivable that Bostonians would be calling for a duck boat parade celebrating any leader of the MBTA. Equally unlikely: passengers embracing or chasing that person down the street for a selfie. Yet such interactions have become commonplace for T general manager Phil Eng.

Under his leadership, public perception of the transit agency has noticeably shifted as the system has steadily improved, and Eng has become a rather unlikely local celebrity in the process. Among his legions

of admirers, he is better known as the “King of Massachusetts” and “Train Daddy Eng.”

“I’m just Phil,” said Eng with a smile.

In the not-so distant past, the T was facing an all-out revolt from fed-up riders. The system was plagued by alarming incidents, including a woman plunging into the Mystic River after a train burst into flames, the dragging death of Robinson Lal-in after his arm got caught in a train door, and a station escalator that suddenly went in reverse, maiming riders.

ENG, Page A7



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

General manager Phillip Eng handed out candy last Valentine’s Day on a commuter rail line. It’s been an odd love affair for some riders.

In wake of Steward, bids for fixes stall

State, federal bills to rein in buyouts of health care assets have bogged down

By Robert Weisman
GLOBE STAFF

Lawmakers spent much of 2024 bemoaning the role of financial giants in health care as hospital chain Steward Health Care, long bankrolled by a private equity firm, collapsed into bankruptcy, putting thousands of jobs and the care of tens of thousands of patients in jeopardy.

Even before Steward shut two Massachusetts hospitals and unloaded six others in a bankruptcy fire sale, a raft of state and federal legislation was filed to create barriers to private health care buyouts. Proponents cited patients’ deaths linked to underinvestment in Steward’s hospitals.

Yet as the grim Steward saga ended this fall, those bills bogged down both in Congress and on Beacon Hill, while regulators approved the sale of Steward’s national physicians group — which includes about 2,500 doctors in Massachusetts — to another private equity firm.

“We really haven’t seen a monumental change,” said Mary Bugbee, health care research director for the Private Equity Stakeholders Project, a watchdog group based in Chicago. “Legislators have a lot to say, but at the end of the day there’s isn’t enough willpower and appetite to actually do something. It’s a huge failure.”

PRIVATE EQUITY, Page A7

IN THE ASHES OF A REVOLUTION



ARIS MESSINIS/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

Looters carried out tables from the Najha military housing complex Monday in southeast Damascus. The leader of the rebel coalition that swept into Damascus and ousted the Assad regime called for a rebuilding of Syria and urged the United States and other nations to remove sanctions imposed on the country. **A4.**

US links Natick man to strike killing soldiers

Prosecutors say suspect, Iranian part of export plot that led to attack in Jordan

By Shelley Murphy and Tonya Alanez
GLOBE STAFF

Two men, including one from Massachusetts, were arrested Monday on federal charges in Boston related to a January drone attack on a US military base in Jordan that killed three American service members and wounded more than 40 others, prosecutors said.

Mahdi Mohammad Sadeghi, 42, of Natick, who has dual citizenship in the United States and Iran, appeared in US District Court in Boston on Monday afternoon to face charges that he conspired to illegally export sensitive technology to Iran that was used to develop the weaponry used in the fatal attack. He was ordered held pending a detention hearing Dec. 27. His attorneys could not be reached for comment.

Mohammad Abedininajafabadi, also known as Abedini, 38, of Tehran, is charged with providing material support to a foreign terrorist organization resulting in death, as well as conspiring with Sadeghi to illegally export sensitive technology.

JORDAN, Page A5

Germany’s governing coalition collapsed, putting Europe’s largest economy in the hands of a caretaker government during a time of financial and security challenges. **A3.**

A 15-year-old student opened fire at a private Christian school in Wisconsin, killing a teacher and another teenager before taking her own life. **A2.**

Federal charges alleging a kickback scheme have sidetracked City Councilor Tania Fernandes Anderson’s once-promising political career. **B1.**

The newest Bruin, Oliver Wahlstrom, is thrilled to be a part of a team he grew up cheering. **C1.**

Trump holds forth on vaccines, drones

President-elect threatens media firms, unveils Japanese bank’s \$100b investment

By Zolan Kanno-Youngs
NEW YORK TIMES

PALM BEACH, Fla. — President-elect Donald Trump said Monday that he was skeptical of mandatory vaccines for schools, threatened more lawsuits against media companies, and accused the Biden administration of hiding the truth about recent drone sightings during his first wide-ranging news conference since the election.

Speaking from his Mar-a-Lago estate in Florida, Trump announced a

►N.Y. judge rejects Trump’s effort to toss hush money conviction. **A6.**

\$100 billion investment from SoftBank, a Japanese technology company, then held forth for more than an hour, jumping from one topic to another in a back-and-forth with reporters.

At one point, Trump suggested that he was being treated better as he enters his second term, this time with more of the Republican Party firmly under his dominance.

“The first term, everybody was fighting me,” Trump said. “In this term, everybody wants to be my friend. I don’t know — my personality changed or something.”

The news conference touched on a range of topics and provided a glimpse into Trump’s priorities as he prepares to take office again next month.

Trump accused the Biden administration of withholding information about an increasing number of mysterious drone sightings in the Northeast.

“The government knows what is happening,” Trump said, though he

TRUMP, Page A6

Divorce filing offers details on lawmaker-lobbyist ties

By Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

Representative Jeff Roy, who last year disclosed his relationship with a top lobbyist, said it had started only recently, after the two Bates College graduates met through the school’s alumni council. But a divorce filing, originally submitted by his wife a day after he disclosed the relationship in a letter quietly filed to the state House clerk, now suggests the romance may have been going on far longer.



Rep. Jeff Roy says his wife’s claims are lies.

In that filing, Maureen Roy wrote that she believed her husband and lobbyist Jennifer Crawford had been together since 2019, and that the Franklin Democrat had been showering her with vacations, expensive meals, and lavish gifts for years. Roy and his wife formally separated in November 2022, documents reveal, but their divorce proceedings — which began in July 2023 — are still ongoing.

The revelations about Maureen Roy’s allegations come after Globe reporting disclosed that Roy, who is chairperson of the House energy committee, and Crawford, who represents several clients regulated by that panel, were in a romantic relationship. Even under Roy’s stated

ROY, Page A10



STAN GROSSFELD/GLOBE STAFF

A WARMING LIGHT, BEFORE WINTER’S SHROUD — The sun can still capture patches of color in this, the final month. Soon, the solstice will flip the script on the waning moments of daylight. A look at December’s light, **As I See It. B1.**



Better call sol

Tuesday: Mild, lots of clouds.
High 55-60, low 35-40.

Wednesday: Cloudy, rain late.
High 45-50, low 35-40.

Sunrise: 7:08. Sunset: 4:13.
Weather and comics, **D5-6.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

VOL. 306, NO. 170

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



0 947725 4